

Dominant Reading: (post-colonial lens)

The novel invites to consider the perspective of convicts in a sympathetic light.

Human's innate desire for a sense of belonging and place in society can manifest into colonial attitudes of ownership.

* Violence of colonialism
→ destructive to both colonised & colonisers

Alternate Reading:

Feminist lens: self-sacrificial quality

* Sal was technically the 'owner'/'master' of Thornhill, however in the end she still ends up conforming to gender norms and being submissive towards him

* She nurtures ~~her~~ the children - As Thornhill doesn't participate in ~~her~~ upbringing as much

* Really wanted to go back to England
→ but ~~was~~ had to sacrifice

Masculinity: they turn to (flowers)
violence to prove themselves 'masculine'

* Social class system of England as oppressive

o historical revisionism present
colonisers as more sympathetic

o In a story ~~about~~ about
Aboriginal ppl → they are voiceless
(zoomorphism)

^{white people for who they are (humanist lens)} Resistant Reading:

The representation of Aboriginal People as 'not-human',
mystified them (humanism)

↳ Aboriginal voices are silenced throughout novel.

While colonisation is bad and destructive
→ it lead to social mobility for European people.

Dominant Reading

view of colonisation and settler culture as destructive.

Critique of Eurocentric values — the convicts/settlers think land should be developed as there are no signs, houses, fields, flocks.

Dharug people are represented as part of the land, but are also mysterious

Destructive to both victims and perpetrators of Colonialism

Colonialism can lead to violence due to human desire for power and ^{material} ownership.

CLARE T. MIKA

ALTERNATE READING!

Colonisers and settlers cause destruction on the landscape, but to an extent deserve our sympathy?

Feminist lens: Sarah is labelled the master of William Thornhill

Men resort to violence when masculinity is threatened

Sarah has to be self-sacrificial

Almost no representation of Aboriginal People.

Colonialism was destructive, but it allowed for people to improve their living standard. (Those in London, who would have otherwise been in poverty.)

RESISTANT reading

Opposite of Dominant Reading

Australia was free land for the taking.

The settlers were right in taking Australia and forming the land.

Aboriginal people did not own the land.

Novel presents Dharug people as a disturbance that inhibits European settlement. However, they are the ones in true harmony with the land.

Dominant

- Commentary on attitudes ~~from~~ the colonisers compared to the values of Indigenous Australians
- more leaning towards the Indigenous values being better

• Thornhill pulls out dairy goat but gets mad when Indigenous people pull up his corn, shows he doesn't understand their way of life

Alternate

- "the importance of land ownership?"
- the imagery of the land, the language Thornhill uses when he finally gets his land
- Thornhill: "His own. His own, ~~the~~ of him standing on it." (when he arrives at his newly owned land)
- And then while he's talking about how he owns every rock and creature in his land, he sees a black crow, who refuses to leave the branch he's sitting on, representing the Aboriginal people

Resistant

- The European coloniser have a better way of life
- Thornhill ends up wealthy at his society glorified while the Aboriginal Australians suffer

What is the dominant reading?

"The face was unrecognisable as a face, the only thing clear the yellow ear of corn stuck between the pink sponge that had been the lips"

"Blood so dark that it was almost black had welled up thick out of the wound, through his shirt"

What is the alternative reading?
fragile masculinity being
emasculated, they
compensate for their
weakness.

Due to

Kenneth + "カキイイ Z'3!"

What
men
their
feeling
fragile
violence
to
compensate
their
own
masculinity.
Lo "In any case for survival he
Henry, Thornhill knew he
have been the & Victor had though
he was a shipwrecked, for instance
the ~~dandy~~ would have pined &
drooped and died".

What is the resistance + reading?

- We should feel sympathy for colonisers because they were discriminated against by higher members of Victorian Society.
- ↳ The early stages of Thornhill's life
- ↳ Blackledge's characterisation

↳ Characterisation

↳ Graphic depiction

"The face was only thing corn stuck that had been 'Blood so dark black had of the wound shirt'"

Dominant

- colonisers don't deserve the sympathy of Australia
 - ↳ the attacks on IA (cut off hand, hung body)
- colonisation was a destructive event that had negative effects on both the colonisers and Indigenous Australians
 - ↳ convicts were forced to go to Aus to avoid death sentence
 - ↳ Indigenous Australians lost their home/land and were attacked
- colonialism is violent

alternate

- gender → women were expected to be positive and nurturing constantly
 - ↳ Sal giving up all her time and energy for her kids
 - ↳ Sal having 5 kids
 - ↳ Sal always joking and looking on the bright side (when Thornhill got convicted)
- race → The British are selfish and greedy
 - ↳ they always refer to something as 'mine'
 - ↳ they keep taking without giving back
 - ↳ Thornhill wants to get more land even though he has a good life where he is
 - ↳ concept of "give a little, take a little"
 - ↳ overfishing
 - ↳ exploitation of resources
- even in a story about Indigenous Australians, there is a lot about them, there isn't really a strong representation of them

Resistant

- colonisers deserve sympathy
 - ↳ Thornhill's experiences in London
 - ↳ he lived in poverty, had to steal to survive
- colonising Australia led to the modernisation making Australia what it is today
 - ↳ built the houses
 - ↳ ~~overfishing~~ the farming (agriculture)
 - ↳ ~~best~~ roads
 - ↳ travel mediums

~~DOMINANT~~

- colonisers' perspective are renounced
 - coloniser's do not deserve our sympathy
 - William's third person limited perspective *↳ Indigenous voices are silenced*
 - graphic visual imagery of the effects that colonisation had on the indigenous *↳ representation of colonisation*
 - ↳ sympathy to the indigenous
 - attitudes and ideals regarding land ownership
 - ↳ ignorant *↳ intelligence was not associated with the indigenous*
 - colonisers rationalising their actions
 - ↳ euphemise the cruel and brutal actions they committed
- Thornhill telling Indigenous to "be off"
- ↳ power hungry
 - ↳ eager to climb the social hierarchy
- objectification of Indigenous
- representation of colonisation as a disease *↳ marginalised*
- ↳ infecting the natural land

alternate

- gender roles:
 - men - egotistical *↳ Thornhill adamant to stay, participating in a massacre so he could get a piece of land*
 - ↳ wanting to own land
 - ↳ greedy
 - ↳ would do anything to climb the social hierarchy
 - women
 - ↳ child carriers *↳ surviving*
 - ↳ follow male counterparts *↳ Sal who follows Thornhill to an unknown land*
- identity crisis
 - ↳ clash in culture *↳ rat poison death of Indigenous (graphic imagery)*
- reverse gender roles
 - ↳ ~~Thornhill~~ Thornhill being given to Sal *↳ Thornhill still decides where they go*
 - ↳ assigned
 - ↳ challenges masculinity *↳ fragile masculinity*
- feminist lens; self-sacrificial

resistant reading

- colonisers deserve our sympathy
 - ↳ forced to do what they did.
 - ↳ were "good" to begin with.
- not all colonisers are bad
 - ↳ forced to / peer pressure / social hierarchy
 - ↳ Thornhill helping the child poisoned by rat poison when no one was watching.
 - ↳ social hierarchy in the colony prevents him from helping the Aboriginals when there are other colonisers around.
 - ↳ e.g. Thornhill uses his status to prevent violence against Aboriginals, threatens Dan with a frogging.
 - ↳ e.g. Thornhill pointing gun but not using it → doesn't want to be an active part of violence against Aboriginals.
 - ↳ e.g. Thornhill struggling to shoot Whicker Harry; struggles to pull the trigger; subconscious attempt to escape the situation.
- social mobility; improve some lives
- humanist lens; evaluate people for who they are.
- not relevant to society

Dominant

Colonialism Reading - Bad

- Bad because ~~you~~ they took the Indigenous Australians culture and traditions away. They broke families apart, took over the Indigenous heritage as well.
- This is a dominant reading because this theme is present throughout the novel, e.g. The British taking over NSW.
- Quotes:
 - "There were no signs that the black felt the place belonged to them. They had no fences that said 'This is mine'..."

Alternate

Neutral

The colonisers acted in an inhumane and cruel manner towards the Indigenous community. For this ~~that~~ we can see them as evil and amoral. However, when taking into consideration the oppression they faced from High English Society, we ~~can see~~ ask ourselves the question, "Were they inherently immoral individuals or moulded into that by their circumstances?". As well as that, we can ask the question, "Who is to blame for the atrocities ~~misdeeds~~ ~~with~~ carried out on Indigenous Australians - the convicts that actually did them or the English High Society that taught them to be cold-hearted and unethical." The Secret River leaves us with more questions about Colonial Australia, then answers.

Resistant

Why the colonial guys are good

Basically, just write about how they were oppressed and from lower society in England. And when they arrived in Australia, they were given power and strength. They did not know how to use that properly because high society in England had always oppressed lower classes and so when they were given power they started acting like the English high society. The colonisers were not inherently heartless and cruel but they ~~are~~ are because of their white European historical significance in Australia's colonial society.

RESISTANT READING

(opposite of dominant)

DOMINANT READING

→ Exploration of the moral and ethical implications of colonial expansion and possession of Indigenous lands

→ colonisation in a more positive light

→ a resistant reading highlights how it may inadvertently reinforce colonial ideologies

→ a resistant reading challenges Thornhill's portrayal of how his pursuit of prosperity ultimately rests upon the violent appropriation of land from the Indigenous



→ sympathetic

→ sanitising brutal reality

→ sympathy for colonisers who were ridiculed by higher society

→ mistreatment and stereotypes for women

→ downplays violent acts and injustices committed by Thornhill

ALTERNATE READING

(feminist, class, etc.)

→ The British settlers and Aborigines are equals

→ classism in the novel was very noticeable as Thornhill made his way up the ranks, starting from nothing and the local Indigenous people could be interpreted as opportunities for cross-cultural learning

→ contextually - in reference to Australian history

→ neutral - mix of the dominant and resistant reading

→ classism in the novel was very noticeable as Thornhill made his way up the ranks, starting from nothing and the local Indigenous people could be interpreted as opportunities for cross-cultural learning

→ masculinity

→ no representation of Aboriginal people

→ Thornhill, instead of asserting dominance, could actively seek to understand and appreciate the Indigenous way of life.

→ effort to bridge the gap between the two cultures

→ reflection on complexity of Aussie history → Clashes between settlers and Aborigines

→ cultural differences

→ violence from British settlers towards Aboriginal

Greenwell's portrayal of both the settlers and the Indigenous characters invites readers to initially examine the impact of colonisation on both sides

→ white people have no respect for Aborigines

→ conflict

Alternate Reading



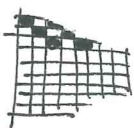
Mix of dominant + resistant reading -

Feminist → self-sacrificial femininity

- Sam lets Thornhill do whatever he does, even though she is his master
- sacrifices herself for her children
- sacrifices her want to go England
- sacrifice beauty for child-bearing.

Emasculation → turns to violence when masculinity repressed.

Rigid Victorian class structures.



Dominant Reading

Colonialism is violent

'Then we saw that they were hands cut off at the wrist. The skin was black against the white of the bone.'

Clashes between Indigenous and whites

Cultural differences.

Moral/Ethical implications of violence towards Indigenous people

Resistant Reading.

Colonialism ~~is good~~ allows for economic growth

Indigenous and white people are not clashing

Indigenous people don't defend their land because it's not settled

'Yellow ear of corn stuck between the pink sponge that had been the lips'

Indigenous man ~~stealing~~ caught stealing, dealing with the pests.

→ Stealing is ~~seen~~ seen as an ~~act~~ criminal act, detrimental to economic growth.

→ Dealing with these aboriginal people ~~by hanging them~~ who commit an act detrimental to economic growth, establishes ~~this~~ a direct step towards economic growth.